

COMMUNICATIONS

That leads us to the last problem area I would like to discuss: lack of communications. Money is an area of marriage that can be used to develop good communications. It is a tool God has given you to learn a great deal about each other. For instance, just talking about the kind of home that you want to live in helps you to learn a lot about each other.

The kind of house we live in doesn't really matter to me. If it weren't for my wife, we'd be sitting around on egg crates and boxes, most probably. In fact, my idea of the ideal house is an all-brick, maintenance-free one-story sitting on green asphalt (no grass). But Judy's ideal home is a two-story colonial on 40 acres of grass. We compromised with a two-story rustic on one acre, and I get to spray every blade of grass with weed killer and cover the yard with pine straw.

However, cars are different. I love machines and select the cars we buy with great care. I want the best buy, best mileage, least maintenance, but that doesn't matter to my wife at all. All she cares about is, "Does it have an automatic and air conditioning?" As we have learned how to talk about these things, we have also learned a lot about each other.

We have also discovered that money is an excellent tool for parents to learn a great deal about their kids' basic values long before questionable values become damaging habits. You'll find out what's really important in their lives. Remember what we discussed earlier? The way you handle money is the clearest outside indicator of what's going on in your life spiritually. The same thing is true about your children. We'll discuss money and children more fully later.

Money is a tool for God to measure our obedience to Him. God's discipline is for our good, not our harm. As Proverbs 13:18 says, "Poverty and shame will come to him who neglects discipline, but he who regards reproof will be honored." I read a story that demonstrates this principle. It seems that a kindergarten was located in a little town that developed into such a thriving community that a four-lane highway was built right next door. When the new road was finished, the traffic